

Controversy **SHAH RUKH KHAN**

“His biggest challenge was to break the shackles of stardom and emerge as a character. This will enable him to complete the transition begun with *Chak De! India*.”

KARAN JOHAR
Director, *My Name is Khan*



“When an icon like Shah Rukh takes a principled stand, people rally around him. This was proved when Mumbai stepped out in huge numbers to watch the film.”

KABIR KHAN
Director, *New York*



Shutter Island. And partly because of the emotional pressure of being with friends and family, trying to answer the unspoken question: “Why did you have to make that comment on TV?” It couldn’t have been easy dealing with the Sena’s viciousness, which ranged from a *Saamna* editorial asked him to “go to Karachi and Islamabad to play cricket with the Pakistanis” to Uddhav Thackeray comparing him to Ajmal Kasab when he said, “Kasab and Shah Rukh are the most secure people in Mumbai.”

It is a trial that Johar feels has added weight to his stardom. “When an icon is a combination of good looks and goodness, talent and strength of character, he becomes more substantial,” he says. Such heroics were, however, not on Shah Rukh’s mind when he started preparing for the role of Rizvan, a character who turns into a Forrest Gumpian folk hero while journeying across the States and attempts to make America see the errors of stereotyping Islam. Rizvan’s journey takes him from the 30,000-strong town of Banville in California to the 204-strong village of Wilhelmina in Georgia. Shah Rukh read books, watched documentaries, met two youngsters suffering from Asperger’s Syndrome, recorded himself in character, watching himself onscreen in his bathroom-cum-video projection room, and even followed a man with the disorder around San Francisco for two days. It was a role without any crutches of stardom. There was no star gaze, because Rizvan has trouble looking people in the eye. There was no flamboyant walk, as his character tends to hop like a penguin. There were certainly no outstretched arms, the signature Shah Rukh gesture seen in countless songs. It was also a film that tackled a difficult issue, even if in a somewhat naïve manner.

Shah Rukh has always taken pride in being a deeply secular Indian as well as a good Muslim. His religion may be something he assumes with cosmopolitan ease but it is certainly one reason why he is embraced so warmly in the Middle East, Indonesia and Malaysia. For Johar, it was a film he felt he was capable of making, one his Lahore-born late father would have been proud of. “He was 40 years older than I was. He wasn’t the kind of father who took me to the park or played sports with me, but he told me his stories of life before the Partition. How some of his closest friends and dearest neighbours had been killed. I still remember him watching TV throughout the day in the years before satel-



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lite television,” says Johar. For Shah Rukh, it was a chance to break the shackles of stardom and further develop his skills as an actor which began with *Swades*. The 80-day shoot in the US and the subsequent 20 days in India gave him an opportunity to exist in the “true world of the film” and become Rizvan.

In Germany, after the film was premiered at Berlinale, it was talked of in the same breath as *Howl* and *The Ghost Writer*, by Rob Epstein-Jeffrey Friedman and Roman Polanski respectively, films dealing with paranoia. Ironically, paranoia on a large scale greeted what Shah Rukh thought to be an innocuous comment on Pakistani cricketers. Though he may now try and make light of the situation—“just because I’m paranoid, it doesn’t mean no one is following me”—it has been a difficult and fraught fortnight. When the first protest broke out, both he and wife Gauri were out of Mumbai. “My mother-in-law, a very sweet and strong lady, was at home with my children. So was my sister but I was still anxious,” admits Shah Rukh.

It was a time, says Johar, not to be over-emotional but pragmatic. What worried both the most was whether people would be safe going to the theatres. Would the aggression against the film translate into attacks on audiences? Shah Rukh was also being